Fasting & Feasting

Leader Guide — For Servants, Parents, and Group Leaders

> *"Is this not the fast that I have chosen: to loose the bonds of wickedness, to undo the heavy burdens, to let the oppressed go free, and that you break every yoke?" — Isaiah 58:6*

Why the Coptic Church Fasts So Much

The Coptic Orthodox Church has the most extensive fasting calendar in all of Christendom — over 200 days each year. To outsiders, this can seem extreme. But to the Coptic faithful, fasting is not a burden. It is a rhythm of life, as natural as breathing in and breathing out.

The Church inherited this discipline from the earliest Christians, who themselves followed Jewish fasting traditions transformed by the teaching of Christ. The Didascalia (3rd century) and the Apostolic Constitutions (4th century) both testify to Wednesday and Friday fasts. The great fasts of Lent, Advent, and the Apostles were well established by the time of the Desert Fathers in Egypt.

The key insight is this: **every fast points toward a feast**. The Great Lent leads to Pascha. The Advent Fast leads to the Nativity. The Virgin's Fast leads to the Assumption. Fasting without feasting would be mere deprivation. Feasting without fasting would be mere indulgence. Together, they teach the soul the pattern of the Gospel: death and resurrection, emptying and filling, the Cross and the Crown.

The Theology of Fasting: Preparation, Not Punishment

It is critical that young people understand: **fasting is not punishment**. It is not about earning God's love or proving our worthiness. God loves us already, fully and completely.

Fasting is **preparation**. Just as an athlete trains before a race, fasting trains the soul for the spiritual life. It teaches self-control, sharpens prayer, and creates space for God. St. Isaac the Syrian wrote: "Fasting is the door to every spiritual joy."

The Coptic understanding of fasting includes three dimensions:

- **Bodily fasting** — abstaining from animal products (and sometimes all food until a set hour). This is the most visible dimension, but it is the least important on its own.
- **Spiritual fasting** — increased prayer, Scripture reading, church attendance, and acts of service. The body fasts from food; the soul feasts on God.
- **Moral fasting** — abstaining from sin, gossip, anger, and selfish behaviour. As Pope Shenouda III taught: "The real fast is fasting from sin."

When all three dimensions come together, fasting becomes a joyful discipline, not a dreaded obligation. This is why the Church sings during Lent, why midnight praises are at their most beautiful during Kiahk, and why the Coptic faithful do not mourn during fasting seasons — they prepare with hope.

The Major Fasts and Their Paired Feasts

The Great Lent → The Resurrection (Pascha)

Fifty-five days of fasting and intensified prayer lead to the greatest feast of the Christian year. Each week of Lent has its own spiritual theme, building toward the overwhelming joy of the Resurrection. The connection is direct: you cannot fully experience the light of Pascha unless you have walked through the darkness of the Cross.

Advent Fast (Nativity Fast) → The Nativity

Forty-three days of preparation for the birth of Christ. The month of Kiahk transforms the midnight praises into extended celebrations of the Theotokos and the Incarnation. As the fast deepens, anticipation builds until the joyful cry: "Christ is born!"

The Apostles' Fast → Feast of Peter & Paul

This variable-length fast (15 to 49 days, depending on the date of Pascha) recalls the apostles' preparation for their mission after Pentecost. It always concludes on the feast of the two greatest apostles, reminding us that spiritual preparation precedes effective service.

Fast of the Virgin Mary → Assumption of St. Mary

Fifteen days of special devotion to the Theotokos, concluding with the celebration of her bodily assumption into heaven. Many families add extra prayers and prostrations during this fast, and churches hold daily liturgies.

Fast of Nineveh → Jonah's Season

Three intense days recalling the repentance of Nineveh after Jonah's preaching. This fast teaches a powerful lesson: genuine repentance can change everything. Even God's declared judgement was turned aside by Nineveh's sincere fasting and prayer.

Wednesday & Friday Fasts → Weekly rhythm

These weekly fasts anchor the entire calendar. Wednesday recalls Judas's betrayal; Friday recalls the crucifixion. Together they ensure that the Passion of Christ is never far from the believer's mind, even in ordinary weeks. They are suspended only during the Fifty Days after Pascha and the days between Nativity and Epiphany.

Practical Fasting Guidance for Different Ages

The Church does not expect the same level of fasting from a seven-year-old and a thirty-year-old. Wisdom and pastoral care guide how fasting is applied:

Young children (under 7)

Children this age are not expected to fast from food. Instead, they can "fast" from something they enjoy — a favourite snack, screen time, or a toy — as a way of learning the concept of self-denial and offering something to God.

Children (7–12)

Many Coptic families begin introducing partial fasting at this age, often starting with the major fasts (Great Lent and Advent). Some children fast from animal products for part of the day or for certain days of the week. The emphasis should be on participation and understanding, not on strictness. Let them feel included, not burdened.

Teenagers (13–18)

By this age, most Coptic young people are capable of full fasting during the major seasons. The challenge is helping them understand *why* rather than just *what*. Teenagers who fast only because their parents make them will likely abandon the practice. Teenagers who understand that fasting is training for a deeper spiritual life will carry it into adulthood.

Adults

Full participation in all the Church's fasts is the norm. However, the Church always allows exceptions for illness, pregnancy, heavy manual labour, and other legitimate reasons. A father of confession can provide guidance for individual circumstances.

> **Key principle:** Never make fasting a source of shame or competition. St. Paul writes: "Let not him who eats despise him who does not eat, and let not him who does not eat judge him who eats" (Romans 14:3). The goal is love, not legalism.

Discussion Prompts

Use these questions during or after gameplay to deepen understanding:

About fasting

- What is the difference between fasting and dieting? Why does the Church fast from animal products specifically?
- Pope Shenouda III said "The real fast is fasting from sin." What do you think he meant?
- Why do you think the Church fasts on Wednesdays and Fridays every single week?
- Can you think of a time when giving something up helped you appreciate it more?
- The people of Nineveh fasted for only three days and God spared their entire city. What does that tell us about the power of sincere repentance?

About feasting

- Why is it important to celebrate and feast, not just to fast?
- Which feast of the Church is your favourite? Why?
- The Fifty Days after Pascha are the only time the Church suspends all fasting. Why do you think that is?
- How does fasting before a feast change the way you experience the feast?

About the calendar

- The Coptic calendar begins with Nayrouz, the Feast of Martyrs. Why do you think the Church starts its year by remembering those who died for Christ?
- Some feasts are "fixed" (same date every year) and some are "moveable" (they change based on Pascha). Why does Pascha move?
- How does following the Coptic calendar shape a person's whole year? How is that different from following only the secular calendar?

Closing Prayer

> *Lord Jesus Christ, You fasted forty days in the wilderness to show us the way of self-denial. You rose from the dead to show us the way of joy. Teach us to fast with willing hearts and feast with grateful ones. Help us to see that every sacrifice we make for You is not a loss but a gain — because in emptying ourselves, we*

> *make room for You to fill us. Through the prayers of the Theotokos and all Your saints who kept the faith through every fast and every feast, have mercy on us. Amen.*